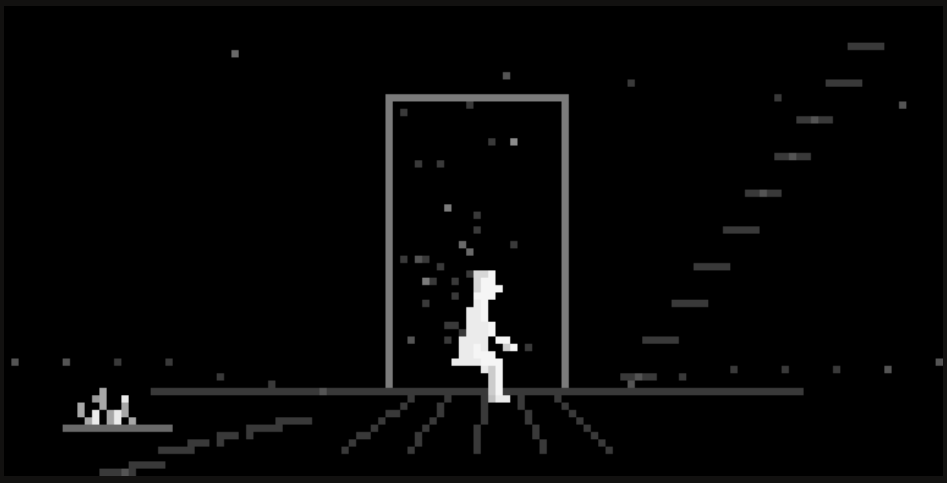


A N A M N E S I

a journey through memories, real and imagined

un luogo moderatamente sicuro

a script for monome norns

The world

Anamnesi is a journey into memories: the real ones and the imagined ones.

It begins at night, in a wood, with a lantern in hand. In a clearing stands a single door, with no house around it. It opens: inside there are stars. And you are on the threshold: the door behind you, a small fire, and ahead the paths, a ladder of light going up and steps going down into the black. Above lies the quiet. Below, everything else.

Each place is a small living world. Someone lives there: sits, gets up, looks out of the window, talks softly to someone who is gone. And each place has its own music, never quite the same twice: a theme runs through all of it, and resurfaces where you least expect it.

The screen is black. Large surfaces are switched off, only their edge remains; things are drawn with a few faint lines, and people are made of light: you can always see who is moving. Text always sits in the black bars, never over the drawing. The cinema is done by the camera: arriving in a place it cranes down or glides into the shot, sometimes it follows a snowflake up into the sky, it shakes when there is pain, cuts on the heartbeat, moves slowly towards an empty chair.

You can walk, or you can stay. Staying is a way of going: some paths only open to those who linger long enough. You can also let it wander on its own, in the background, and look up now and then.

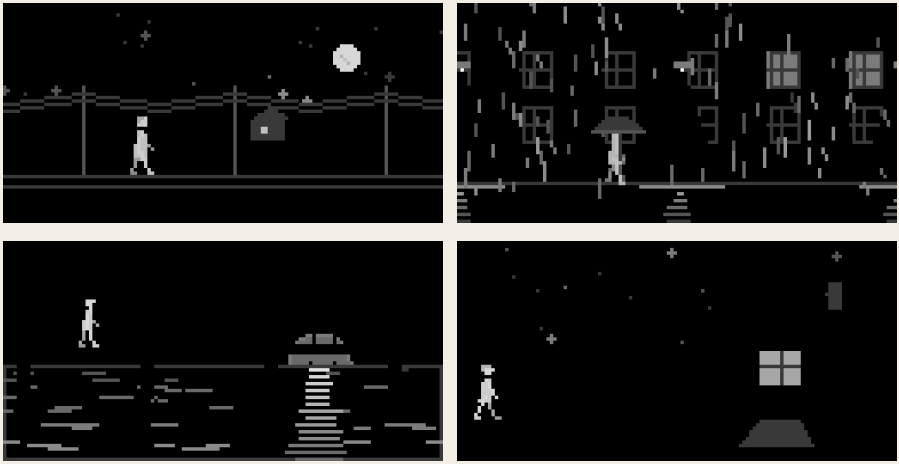


The journeys

Between one place and the next there is no loading screen: there is a short film. First a black title card, with the chapter number and the name of the place you are heading to. Then an episode of two shots, with him in it: a wide shot and a close-up.

A road at night with telegraph poles and a passing car. Streetlights in the rain. A bridge at sunset. Stairs climbing towards the light and stairs going down into the dark. A bicycle among the poplars, the night bus, the train seen from inside and outside, snow, the sea, a lantern, a lit window with the grandparents at the table. The episode chooses itself, according to the direction, the layer and the time of day of the place you are reaching, and it never repeats straight away.

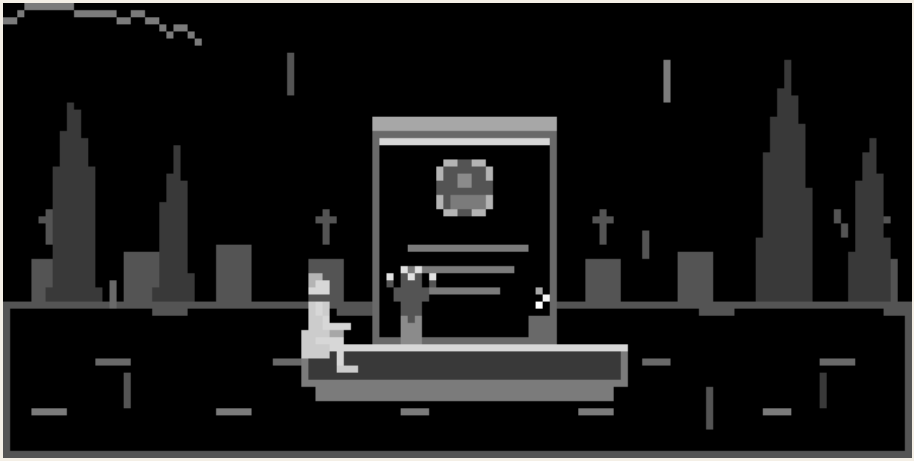
Meanwhile the music builds a bridge: the strings hold a chord and the piano hints at the theme, softly. If you are in a hurry, K3 during the journey skips to the end of the episode.



How to walk

K2	choose a path: up, down, left, right, and the hidden ones
K3	walk towards the chosen path (during a journey: skip the episode)
E1 E2 E3	the place's three macros: each place has its own. One full turn goes from end to end
K1 + K2	evoke: the strings rise, the theme returns, the place says another sentence and starts again with new chords
K1 + K3	now / back then: the scene becomes an old photograph with its date, time slows, he becomes a child again; the music turns to worn tape and music box
K1 + E1	volume
K1 + E2	scroll through the paths
K1 + E3	space: more or less reverb

Nothing changes abruptly, but everything can be heard: every knob and key glides sound and light over two or three seconds. The K1 combinations work in every place, and during journeys too.



The macros

Each place assigns three macros to the three knobs. A macro moves many things at once: the sound, the voices that play and, often, what you see (the rain in the rain, the wind in the trees, the dark of night). When you arrive somewhere, the knobs take that place's values. The macro's name appears at the top right while you turn.

strings	a string orchestra slowly enters
heartbeat	the heart becomes audible, and quickens
warm / cold	from cold and glassy to warm and round
bells	the bells ring more often
choir	a choir holding the chords
far / near	everything moves near or far
echo	a tape echo that repeats and recedes
leaves	rustling leaves, wind in the branches
people	people around, voices, glasses
fragility	the memory wears out: tape, dust, forgotten notes
hurry	hurry: the tempo speeds up, the ticking, the heart
fire	the fire grows, the sound warms
childhood	a music box doubles the melody, the tape yellows
tears	slow strings, more space, held breath
light / shadow	the musical mode rises to light or sinks to shadow
machines	the rhythm of machines, presses, gears
sea	the waves, louder and closer
fog	everything veils over and fades into space
neurosis	shards, heartbeat, wavering pitch
night	crickets, owls, dark, fewer notes
rain	the rain, and the falling drops
depth	the low end opens, melodies sink
radio	a distant radio, through the static
breath / suspended	from suspended and sparse to full and flowing
memory	the theme returns more often, with echo
objects	the objects on the table: how many play, from none to all
silence	voices withdraw, space remains
stars	celesta sparkles, rising light
faster / slower	faster or slower

torment	pain you can hear: noise, ringing, static, beating clusters, scraped metal
train	a train passing, far away
wind	the wind rises, and moves things
glass	FM glass chimes and a cloud of grains
voices	voices and whispers all around

The seven layers

From top to bottom: peace at the summit, the abyss at the bottom. With K2 you choose a direction: up leads towards quiet, down towards the night of the mind. Left and right keep you on the same layer.

THE SKY

The wind harp · The sea of stars · The star carousel · Under the stars · Happiness · Birth · Snow falling upwards · Above the clouds · Flight · Letters in the wind · The cloud orchestra · The garden · The eclipse · The rose of light · The comet · The silence of thoughts · The cloud train · The lullaby · After the storm · The top floor · The return · The northern lights · The grandparents' dance · The whale in the sky · The ladder in the sky · Rebirth · The lanterns · The hot-air balloon · Peace · The other side · The library of the sky · The glass field

THE HEIGHTS

The windmill · The sledge · The mountain path · The sea of fog · The meeting · The frozen waterfall · Walking in the woods · Accepting · The echoing lake · The woodcutter · Chestnuts · The mountain lake · The bridge of towers · The waterfall · The bell ringer · The sunflowers · The summit · The beech wood · The observatory · Lost on the mountain · The spring · Atop the bell tower · The storm from the hill · The city rooftops · The flock · The rope bridge · The walls of Amelia · The hermitage · The tower of memories · The piano in the woods · The mountain hut · Skates on the lake · The upside-down city · The bonfire · The cabin · The cable car

CHILDHOOD

Hide and seek · By the sea · The go-kart · The river · The Commodore 64 · The night of falling stars · Soap bubbles · The smells of long ago · Marbles · Tapes off the radio · Country road · The tree house · Grandpa's hand · The circus · The grape harvest · The tin drum · Summer at the grandparents' · June · The chair swing ride · Fireflies · The school play · The electric train · The room you'd forgotten · Christmas bingo · The hayloft · The first day of school · The nativity scene · The courtyard · The bumper cars · Being ill · The village fair · The match in the square · Grandpa's vegetable patch · The classroom · The hall of mirrors · No stabilisers · The arcade · Lost at the market · The olive mill · The little red car · The first memory · The ice lolly · The carpeted room · Afraid of the storm · The fever · Waking · The hollow in the woods · The puddles

THE VILLAGE

The night train · The village band · The empty station · The pastry shop · The distant city · The Saturday market · Sunday in the village · The bus stop · The blacksmith · After the party · At the barber's · The outskirts · The church at night · The newsstand · The old town · The train that's leaving · The summer square · The open-air cinema · The centre of everything · The petrol station at night · Fornole at sunset · The dance hall · The sports ground at night · The village festival · The roads in the fog · New Year's Eve · The threshold · The launderette · The fountain in the square · The lit windows · The storm in the square · The rehearsal room · The playground · Snow on the village · The crossroads · The flea market · The phone booth · The record shop · The blackout · The library of names · The print shop · The shop at night · The monumental cemetery · The projection room · The procession · The winter swimming pool · The cemetery at night · Inside the tower clock · The funeral chapel · The abandoned town · Visiting Massimo · The film studio · The

bakery at night · The studio · The abandoned set

THE HOUSES

The cellar · Rain on the roof · The alarm clock · The empty chair · The abandoned house · The sewing machine · Day after day · The hanging coat · The lullaby · The orphanage · The rotary phone · She reads · The dormitory · The wait · The stairs in the dark · The washing machine · Your son · The refectory · Late-night tv · The photographs · The fridge at night · The washroom · The attic · Dinner in silence · The box room · Under the stairs · The bathroom at three · The infirmary · Grandfather between rooms · Moving out · The visiting room · The letter never sent · The closed door · The old bed · The neighbour's window · The orphanage stairs · Before sleep · The birthday · The room of the one who's gone · The day of the funeral · The wardrobe of her clothes · The empty house · The suitcase · The lady under the veil · The book for her · The voice you can't recall · The radio at night · The vigil · The record player · The mother you never saw · The hospital at night · The last breath · Twenty-five years later

THE MIND

The panic attack · The endless queue · Voices in the head · The clocks · Unrequited love · A broken family · Judgement · The migraine · The exam · Being someone's pain · Fear of the dark · The maze · Doubt · Running late · The deconsecrated chapel · The mirror · The ringing · Renouncing · The lift · The crowd · The nightmare · The emergency room · The asylum · The masks · Three in the morning · Insomnia · Locked in, screaming · Missed calls · The faces you can't remember · The missed chances · The call at night · The shadow that won't follow · The life you never had · The rising water · Running away · The shrinking room · Forgetting oneself · Anger · The train that won't stop · The aquarium · No one talking · The crack in the ceiling · The cold floor · The lengthening shadows

THE ABYSS

The fall · The marsh · The fire · The crypts · The mine · The hammer · The river of forgetting · The abandoned asylum · The shipwreck · The closed factory · The black river · The abandoned hospital · The closed subway · The dark lighthouse · The silent shop floor · The black hole · The well · Beneath the roots · The last train · The drowned world · Rock bottom · The drowned village · The open sea · The cage · The desert of ash · Those down there · Crying · Under the ice · The chains · The howling wind · The deep wood · The void · The last echo · The light at the end · Pain · Before being born · The landslide

And then there are the places that aren't on the map. They open only if you stay long enough in the right spot. One of them never ends.

The music

Each place has its own tonic, mode, progression and a group of voices that come and go by themselves. Beneath it all is a breath: four voices gliding from chord to chord over many seconds.

Twenty-nine instruments, all synthesised live: felt piano, electric piano, celesta, music box, guitar, choir, a humming voice, strings, harmonium, organ, accordion, flute, bells, singing bowls, arcade square waves, an old radio. And five new engines: FM glass chimes, a cloud of grains, scraped resonant metal, soft detuned saws like an old synth, clusters of close notes beating against each other.

Thirty-five soundscapes: rain, wind, sea, fire, crickets, cicadas, swallows, cowbells, a train, a typewriter, a singing photocopier, and those of pain: a hissing noise, ringing in the ears, static, machines, a distant shriek. They switch on only when needed, so the norns can breathe.

The lower you go, the more it hurts, and you can hear it. In the mind and the abyss the music gets dirty: noise swells at the peak, the pitch wavers, chords tighten until the notes beat against each other. The panic attack, the migraine, insomnia, the call at night, the fire: there pain is not told, it is heard. The torment macro raises or lowers it. The signal never saturates, though: every place is balanced, and a limiter always keeps it below zero.

Each place has its own song: a melancholy melody born from its name, which comes back the same every time you return, so you recognise it. The place tells it in sections, like a real piece: the theme; then another room of the same house, with chords changing more often and sometimes a second, lower melody; then the peak, with the song up high, a second string voice beneath and sometimes a key change heralded by reversed tape; then the suspended part, almost nothing. Every change can be heard: a roll, a low hit, a breath.

Many places have the rhythm of objects, as in ERMO: a table with sixteen spots, and on each spot an object that plays in its own way, a single hit, two or three repeats, a triplet, a group of four in the time of

three. Wood, brushes, metal, glass, a heart, a machine. At every section the table turns and something moves. In many scenes you can see it: the woodcutter's axe, the blacksmith's hammer, the sticks on the tin drum fall exactly on the hits.

In some rooms there is hurry: a note keeps beating, the tempo speeds up within each section and resets only at the change. The train that is leaving, the exam, the alarm clock, the rising water, the child lost at the market.

When you enter a place you know it at once: a low hit, the place's chord, and its song starting from the beginning.

Each place has an arc of a few minutes: it opens, reaches its peak, empties out into silence. If you stay and listen, you never hear the same round twice.

In the houses, the mind and the abyss a low string line descends step by step, like a lament. The piano is felted: every note begins with a soft thud, and sometimes leaves a small echo an octave above.

The melodies breathe like a voice: they swell towards the middle of the phrase and fade at the end, arrive a little late, often close with an appoggiatura, a note that falls like a sigh. Chords sometimes enter with a suspended fourth and resolve later. When the theme returns, the strings rise softly beneath it.

Parameters

lingua / language	Italian or English (also chosen at start-up)
macro 1, 2, 3	the three knobs, MIDI-mappable
ora / allora	now or back then
parole / words	how often the sentences appear: often, sometimes, never
carattere / font	pixel, crisp without accents; soft, with accents
vagare / wander	after a few untouched minutes, it sets off again by itself
inizio / start	begin from the threshold or the last place
prologo	always, only the first time, never

Installation

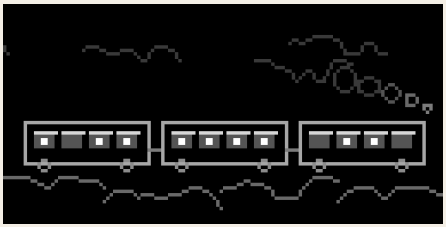
From maiden:

```
;install https://github.com/unluogomoderatamentesicuro/anamnesi
```

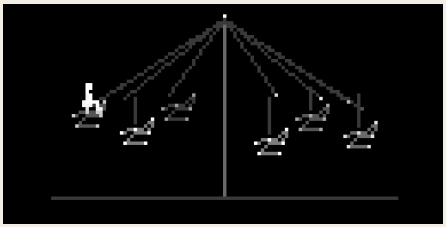
On first launch you need SYSTEM > RESTART, because the audio engine is new. The engine uses only standard SuperCollider components.

At start-up choose the language with E2 and confirm with K3. Any key skips the prologue.

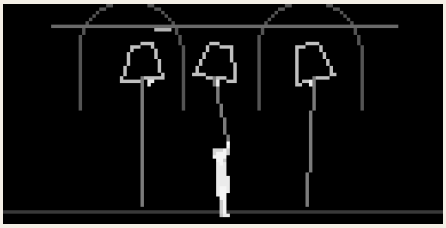
Some places



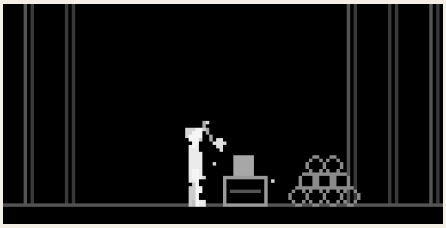
The cloud train



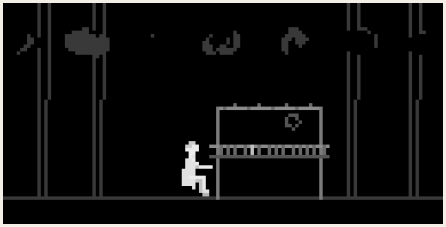
The star carousel



The bell ringer



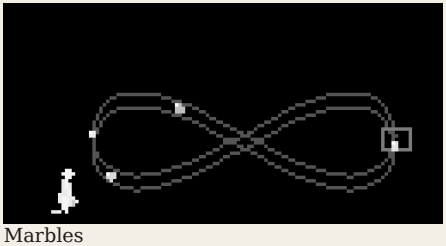
The woodcutter



The piano in the woods



The tin drum



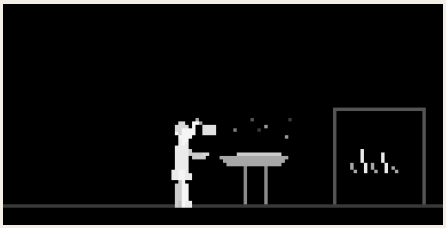
Marbles



The nativity scene



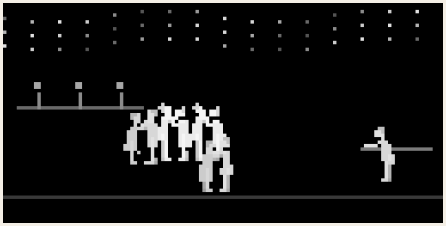
Inside the tower clock



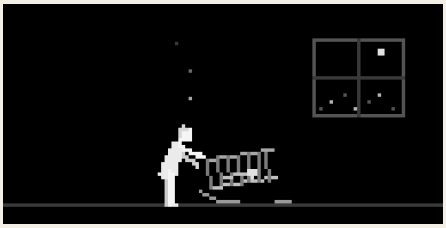
The blacksmith



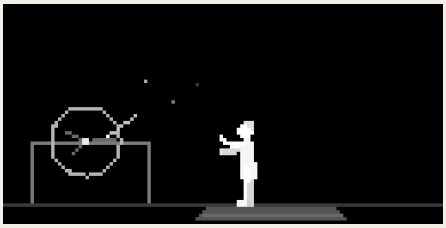
The blackout



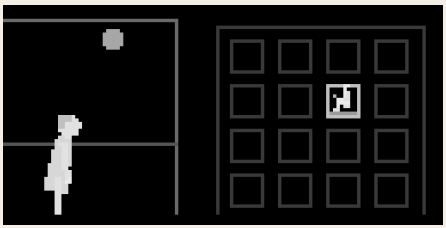
The dance hall



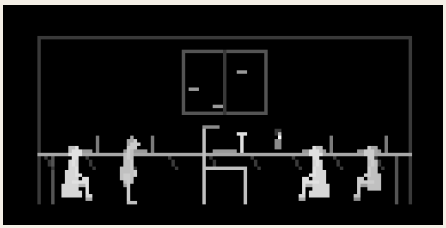
The lullaby



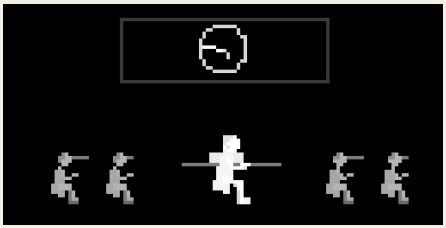
The record player



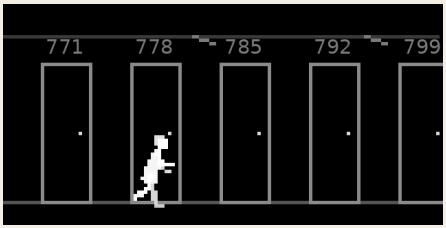
The neighbour's window



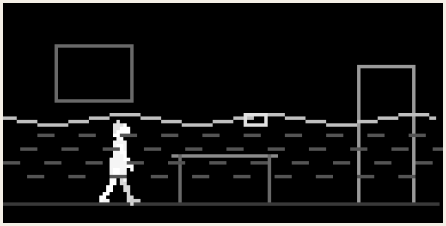
The empty chair



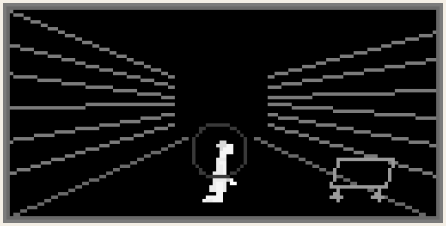
The exam



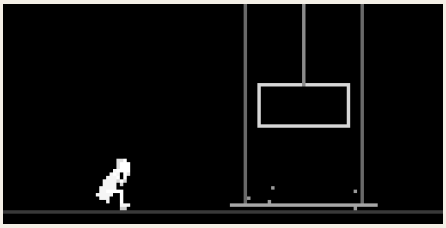
Running late



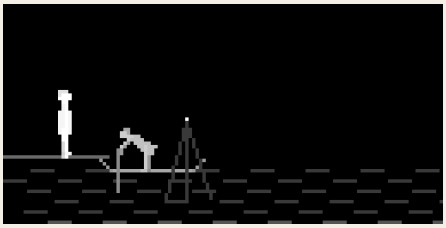
The rising water



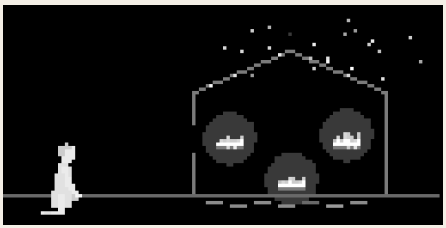
The panic attack



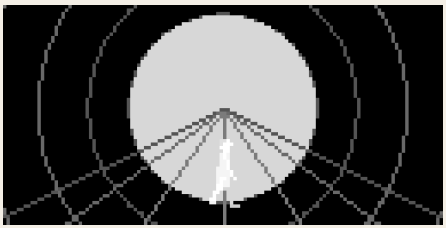
The hammer



The black river



The fire



The light at the end

For Massimo, for my grandparents,
and for those who remain.

un luogo moderatamente sicuro